

continue scrolling Instagram or TikTok for hours, long after it's stopped satisfying any part of us – but you can't 'complete' shopping in the same way that you can't ever finish the scroll. There will always be a way to 'level up' your life according to some arbitrary external measure – more clothes, fancier holidays, a bougier sofa, better eyebrows. I suspect many of us are subconsciously waiting for that magical moment to come where some internal checklist of 'stuff' is completed, and we can live happily ever after. I am here to tell you that, as far as I can tell, that moment does not exist. We have to define it for ourselves.

Some of this is innate and primal, but much of it is, well, capitalism and consumerism. We are conned into thinking that 'settling' is something awful, repulsive – as though being content is the worst thing that could ever happen to us – because aspiration makes us more profitable. It's true that settling for things that are inherently not right for you, or less than you deserve, is not a good thing – especially in some areas of your life, such as a partnership where the other person is not contributing enough or a job where your salary doesn't reflect your value. Often, we accept these things when our self-esteem is low, because we don't believe we're worth more, and that's something that we have to fight. But that's not the kind of 'settling' that I'm talking about here. I'm talking about rejecting the need to constantly level up – the need to always have the latest model of something, or a bigger house, or a newer car. There is such an oversupply of stuff, such